The Spring, Autumn, and The Warring States Period

Chinese history marks the time between 772 and 476 BCE as the Spring and Autumn Period. It is named after the *Spring and Autumn Annals*, which is a collection of chronicles that speak about the government of this time. The collection is the earliest source that speaks about the legendary Sun Tzu. This period in time is known as the ending of the Western Zhou period when the government moved the capital to Luoyang in the modern-day Henan Province. This began a new era known as the Eastern Zhou period. It is here that some of the greatest Chinese thinkers emerged. Taoism, Confucianism and Mohist philosophies were introduced by these thinkers. However, various regions separated from the main government at Luoyang and declared themselves to be independent states.

This breaking away from the main government gave rise to what is known as the Warring States Period. Between 476 and 221 BCE, the seven states continuously fought each other in hopes of becoming stronger. These states included Zhao, Yan, Chu, Qin, Wei, Han and Qi. All of them declared independency but none of them acknowledged the right to the Mandate of Heaven, which was still possessed by the state of Zhou in Luoyang. Since all of the states employed similar battle strategies and had armies of similar strength, none of them was able to rise above the others. Mo Ti was a philosopher and engineer who acted as a spy among each state. He was loyal to no state and readily provided intelligence to whomever he wished. His objective was to stop any one state from overpowering another so that they would all eventually give up and form a peace treaty. He desired an end to the war and is seen by many as a peacemaker in history. However, Mo Ti did not succeed and sometime between 262 and 260 BCE, the state of Qin conquered Zhao at the Battle of Changping.

It was Shang Yang of Qin (d. 338 BCE) who initiated an extensive series of reforms including the Qin belief that victory should be the main objective at any cost. However, it is Sun Tzu who is given credit for reorganizing military strategies and tactics in battle. Some scholars are divided as to whether it was Shang Yang or Sun Tzu who reformed the military. It seems likely that Shang Yang was familiar with *The Art of War*, which is